location on Bras Basah Road is today occupied by the Raffles City Shopping Mall, just across from the famous Raffles Hotel. As anyone visiting Singapore will have noticed, the liberal use of the founder's name can be quite confusing.

THE GREAT INDIAN ARC OF THE MERIDIAN

As the British became more entrenched in India, they quickly discovered the need for good maps of the country's interior to help with administration, revenue collection and military movements. Till the mid-seventeenth century, European mapping had been concentrated on the coastline but now the interiors had to be systematically charted too. The key survey tool was the perambulator—essentially a large wheel set up to allow the measurement of distance. East India Company troops would often take a perambulator along on marches and an estimate of distance would be worked out by adjusting for the twists and turns of the road. While this was hardly accurate, it provided readings that were a vast improvement on earlier estimates. For instance, a map of Sri Lanka and the Coromandel coast from this era carries the note, 'The route from Tritchinapoly to Trinevelly ascertained by a march of English troops in 1755'. This was quite typical.

With the conquest of Bengal, the British decided to carry out a more scientific survey of their new possessions. In 1765, Robert Clive assigned James Rennell, a young naval officer, the task of making a general survey of Bengal. Rennell took a detachment of sepoys and criss-crossed the countryside for seven years fixing latitudes, plotting productive lands and marking rivers and villages. It was hard and dangerous work. While surveying the Gangetic delta (the Sunderbans), Rennell wrote in his notebook 'We have no other Obstacles to carry on our Business properly than the extensive thickets with which the country abounds, and the constant dread of Tygers, whose vicinity to us their Tracks, which we are constantly trampling over, do fully demonstrate'. [4]